

The Ultimate Liquid Playlist: An Integrated Marketing Campaign and Brand Repositioning for SONIC Drive-In

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1. Strategic Foundation

Context & Opportunity

Among Gen Z and younger Millennials, non-alcoholic beverages have become more than simple refreshments. Drinks are now often part of “fun drink” culture, where consumers care about customization, visual appeal, and the overall experience (Cording, 2025; Patel, 2026). SONIC, which was acquired by Inspire Brands for \$2.3 billion in 2018 (Inspire Brands, 2018), is still categorized primarily as a hamburger QSR rather than a beverage destination. With over 10,000,000 app downloads, SONIC already has the digital reach to support customization and drive beverage purchases.

I focus on SONIC’s extensive customizable beverage menu, using the classic Cherry Limeade, one of SONIC’s signature beverages, as the primary example. Cherry Limeade also has strong brand recognition beyond the restaurant experience, with SONIC launching Cherry Limeade drink mixes for retail purchase in 2021 (Eubank, 2021). When repositioning SONIC for young adults, I wanted to connect its customizable beverages to the growing “fun drink” culture among young consumers (Cording, 2025). SONIC offers an extensive range of customization options with cream, candy, slushie, syrup, and fruit add-ins. The Cherry Limeade also provides a recognizable entry point for the repositioning because of its long association with the SONIC brand.

However, SONIC’s extensive customization can also create a choice-overload problem. The

opportunity is therefore not to overwhelm consumers with the sheer number of combinations, but to pair that range with a guided structure that makes exploring it feel easy and personal.

Brand Evolution & Recent Marketing

While SONIC leans on its nostalgic drive-in identity, its recent marketing efforts have actively targeted younger demographics through agile, culturally relevant campaigns. Transitioning away from its decades-long "The Two Guys" format, SONIC began showcasing unscripted, authentic customer moments in its 2020 "This Is How We SONIC" campaign (Business Wire, 2020). By 2024, the brand partnered with Mother Los Angeles for the character-driven "Live Free. Eat SONIC" platform (Shots Magazine, 2024). Furthermore, SONIC has increasingly used social-first and culturally relevant campaigns to reach younger audiences, such as the 2025 "Save a Pumpkin" parody PSA opposing the industry's pumpkin spice trend (Business Wire, 2025b; Thorn, 2025b), and the highly interactive "Big Dill Meal" collaboration with Grillo's Pickles (Business Wire, 2025a; Thorn, 2025a).

Together, these campaigns suggest that SONIC has already begun moving beyond its traditional drive-in image. Its brand communication approach now has strong cultural inclusiveness and focuses on calling for widespread social participation. This has laid the foundation for its new positioning centered around beverages.

Competitors

Unlike specialty beverage brands that focus on customizable drinks and traditional fast-food restaurants where drinks are not the main attraction, SONIC combines extensive drink customization with its signature drive-in experience.

For the young adult demographic, Dutch Bros is a massive emerging competitor. Demonstrating the

intense demand for beverage-first drive-through models, Dutch Bros continued its aggressive expansion by opening 151 new shops in 2024 and officially opening its 1,000th location in early 2025 (Retail & Leisure International, 2025). Dutch Bros focuses almost exclusively on customizable coffee, energy drinks, and teas served through a drive-through. Dutch Bros also offers a Cherry Lime Myst, which is a “juicy blend of cherry and lime” similar to the Cherry Limeade from SONIC (Cherry Lime Myst, 2026). To compete with Dutch Bros, SONIC can differentiate through the combination of its beverage combinations, nostalgic brand equity, and its distinctive drive-in experience.

Target Audience Segmentation

This campaign aims to reposition SONIC’s customizable beverages as a fun and relevant drink choice for younger consumers by increasing awareness of SONIC’s drink combinations and encouraging app-based customization and purchase.

Primary Audience: Youth and young adults

Demographics: College students and young professionals aged 18-26; Regular fast-food and beverage purchasers; Heavy mobile and social media users.

Psychographics: They value personalization, authenticity, and self-expression. They enjoy trying trendy food and drinks and are often influenced by social media and current consumer trends.

Recent beverage trends suggest that younger consumers increasingly view drink choice as part of personalization and self-expression. For them, a drink can be a small form of self-expression. This digitally native audience is accustomed to filtering and rapidly switching between options, which is the same behavior as how they consume music and digital media. A traditional, static drink menu does not align with this mindset; instead, they require a dynamic system that allows them to save and

shuffle their choices.

The campaign therefore lowers the barrier to entry by adopting selected combinations and social media-inspired templates, making customization feel guided rather than intimidating. This approach enables SONIC to transform its wide range of options into personalized beverage experiences, thereby converting the existing customization features into the primary reason for consumers to choose this brand.

Strategic Positioning

Single-Minded Proposition: SONIC lets young consumers personalize their favorite drinks to reflect their moods, preferences, and moments.

Brand Position Statement: To young consumers seeking fun and personalized beverage experiences, SONIC is the drive-in where a nostalgic favorite like Cherry Limeade can become a drink that feels entirely their own.

Rationale: This positioning connects SONIC's existing strength in beverage customization with a consumer need for more personalized and approachable choices. It frames the playlist as a way to create drinks for different moods and moments. Cherry Limeade serves as a familiar starting point that connects SONIC's existing brand image with younger consumers.

2. The Core Concept

Big idea: The Ultimate Liquid Playlist

Campaign Tagline: Your Flavor, On Shuffle.

Concept Description: The Ultimate Liquid Playlist uses the familiar structure of a music playlist as a

way to organize and communicate SONIC's beverage customization. This concept integrates personalized customization into ready-made combinations, so that consumers don't have to choose among numerous individual options. Just as people create music playlists to match different occasions, SONIC lets customers build, revisit, and shuffle their own collection of drinks. The primary print ad visualizes this idea through a smartphone playlist filled with customized SONIC drinks instead of songs. The concept also extends into an in-app playlist feature, where users can customize, save, and revisit their favorite drink combinations through a familiar playlist structure.

3. Creative Execution

Brand Standards & Visual Identity



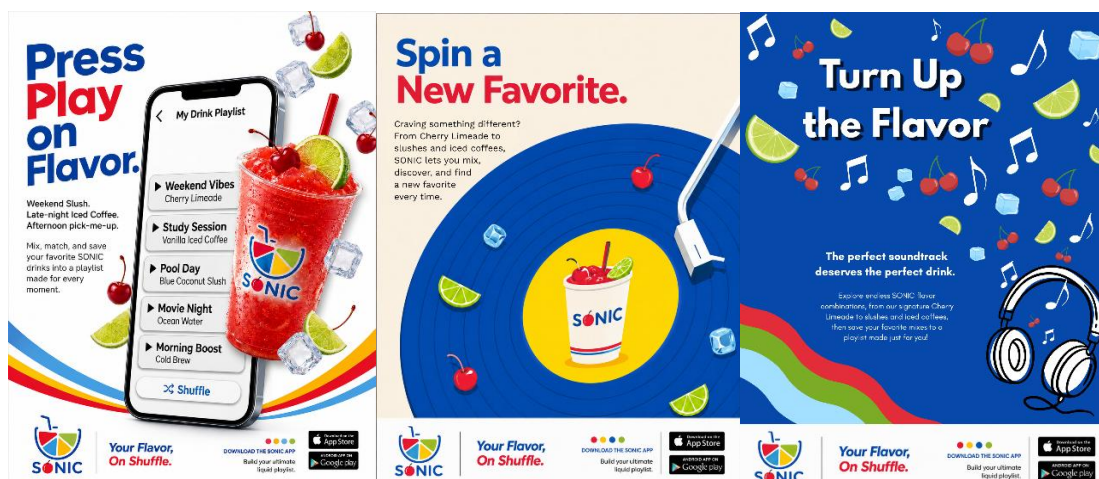
Brand Identity Rationale: SONIC Drive-In is a classic fast-food brand known for its drive-in culture and customizable drinks. This brand identity system focuses on Cherry Limeade and customized beverages, supporting the campaign's repositioning of SONIC as a more fun, youthful, and personal

beverage destination. The visual aesthetic combines SONIC's nostalgic drive-in energy with a brighter, more modern look. The campaign logo uses a cup-shaped citrus symbol, bold rounded typography, and vibrant drink-inspired colors to suggest flavor variety, customization, and self-expression.

Logo Usage: The SONIC Cherry Limeade logomark should be used primarily in its full-color version. Clear space should be kept around the logo to maintain readability. When full color is not possible, alternate treatments such as one-color, reverse, black and white, or grey may be used depending on background and printing needs.

Typography: Both Open Sans and Work Sans may be used in this brand system. All type used within the campaign should follow these typefaces. Work Sans should be used for all body copy, while Open Sans should be reserved for headline copy.

Print Campaign



Ad 1: "Press Play on Flavor"

-Headline: Press Play on Flavor.

-Body Copy: Weekend Slush. Late-night Iced Coffee. Afternoon pick-me-up. Mix, match, and save your favorite SONIC drinks into a playlist made for every moment.

Ad 2: "Spin a New Favorite"

-Headline: Spin a New Favorite.

-Body Copy: Craving something different? From Cherry Limeade to slushes and iced coffees, SONIC lets you mix, discover, and find a new favorite every time.

Ad 3: "Turn Up the Flavor"

-Headline: Turn Up the Flavor

-Body Copy: The perfect soundtrack deserves the perfect drink. Explore endless SONIC flavor combinations, from our signature Cherry Limeade to slushes and iced coffees, then save your favorite mixes to a playlist made just for you!

30 Second Video Commercial Storyboard

Seconds	Voiceover & Sound Effects	Scene Descriptions
0:00 - 0:02	VO: Same playlist. SFX: Low car ambience; faint repetitive music loop.	Close-up of a plain gray drink sitting in the center console of the parked car. The cup has no ice, color, or visible customization. The low-saturation lighting establishes a dull and repetitive mood.

0:02 - 0:05	VO: Stuck in the same mood? SFX: Repetitive music continues, then briefly skips.	Medium interior shot of the main character sitting in the driver's seat and scrolling absent-mindedly on her phone. Her expression is bored. The exterior environment remains muted.
0:05 - 0:07	VO: "Maybe it's time to change the track." SFX: Phone tap; app-opening chime.	Over-the-shoulder close-up as the main character taps the redesigned SONIC App icon. The character and car remain muted, while the colorful app logo creates the first strong visual contrast.
0:07 - 0:09	No VO SFX: Music begins to build; soft hologram and swipe sounds.	A transparent holographic menu projects upward from the phone. Colorful drink cards appear like album covers.
0:09 - 0:11	VO: Pick your flavor. SFX: Interface clicks; soft selection chimes.	The interface changes to a playlist-style customization screen, with drink combinations presented as mood-based "tracks." The main character taps Cherry Limeade as her base flavor.
0:11 - 0:14	VO: Make it yours! SFX: Two selection clicks; rising beat; Mix button	The main character selects peach and mango as additional flavors, then taps the circular Mix button.

	activation.	
0:14 - 0:16	VO: Now hit shuffle. SFX: Beat drop; ice clinks; liquid splashes; sparkling whoosh.	Front view through the windshield. The holographic menu disappears as cherries, peach slices, mango pieces, ice cubes, water droplets, and mood emojis begin swirling around the main character.
0:16 - 0:18	No VO SFX: Light engine sound; upbeat music continues; magical whoosh.	High-angle exterior shot. The car follows the drive-through lane toward the pickup area. The colorful trail of fruit, ice, water, and emojis flows from the driver's window and leads toward the restaurant.
0:18 - 0:20	Dialogue (Employee): "One Cherry Limeade with a little chill." SFX: Service-window slide; cup handoff; soft notification chime.	Interior view toward the drive-through window. A uniformed employee hands the main character her pink-and-yellow frozen drink and a bright yellow Chill emoji sticker.
0:20 - 0:22	No VO SFX: Sip; ice movement; bright musical transition.	Low-angle close-up from inside the car. The main character takes her first sip and reacts with delighted surprise. Cheerful emojis float around her, and the entire image shifts into bright, saturated color.

0:22 - 0:24	VO: One sip, new mood. SFX: Car door opens; upbeat music.	Exterior medium shot in bright daylight. The main character steps out of the black car holding her customized drink. A transparent three-dimensional Chill emoji bubble floats above her.
0:24 - 0:26	VO: However you're feeling, there's a flavor for it. SFX: Natural laughter; park ambience; music continues.	First-person wide shot as the main character approaches a picnic table surrounded by friends. Each person has a different colored SONIC drink and a matching mood bubble.
0:26 - 0:28	No VO SFX: Drink clink; friends laughing; upbeat music peaks.	Overhead close-up of four friends bringing their drinks together for a toast.
0:28 - 0:30	VO: Your Flavor, On Shuffle. Find your next favorite in the SONIC App. SFX: Upbeat music resolves with a bright SONIC chime.	The SONIC logo shows at the center. A vertical divider separates the logo from the campaign tagline: Your Flavor, On Shuffle. The CTA appears at the bottom center: Find your next favorite in the SONIC App.

4. Integrated Communication Strategy

The positioning is an integrated strategy that includes paid, owned, social and earned channels. Its communication strategy emphasizes SONIC's beverage customization as a way to create drinks that

fit individual moods, preferences, and everyday moments.

Paid Media Strategy: Print and video introduce the Liquid Playlist concept and communicate the value of customization.

Owned Media Strategy: The SONIC app turns the concept into a functional playlist experience where users can customize, save, and revisit drinks.

Social Media Strategy: User-generated drink combinations can extend the playlist metaphor into shareable content, allowing consumers to showcase their customized drinks, discover combinations from peers, and turn individual drink choices into social content.

Earned Media Strategy: Target food and marketing trade media that cover brand repositioning, QSR trends, and consumer behavior.

Journalist: E.J. Schultz, News Editor, Ad Age

E.J. Schultz is a strong fit because he regularly reports on food and beverage brands, marketing campaigns, and how well-known companies change their strategies to stay relevant. Since my story is about SONIC changing its brand image, his reporting interests match my repositioning well. Ad Age is also a strong fit because its readers include marketers, advertisers, and business professionals who are interested in branding and consumer trends. Coverage from Ad Age would give the repositioning credibility through trusted third-party media rather than paid advertising alone.

Written Media Pitch

Subject: Story Idea: How SONIC Is Rethinking Its Role in Today's Beverage Culture

Hi E.J. Schultz,

I'm reaching out with a story idea about how established QSR brands are responding to the growing "fun drink" trend by rethinking how young consumers interact with their menus.

SONIC offers a useful case study. While its extensive beverage customization is a core strength, the sheer number of options can easily cause choice overload. By organizing these combinations into a digital "playlist," SONIC is adopting the familiar swipe-and-shuffle behavior of music apps to solve this problem. This communication strategy, titled "The Ultimate Liquid Playlist," uses music curation as an organizing metaphor. Like choosing songs for different moods, customers can create drink combinations that fit different moments throughout their day, turning an overwhelming menu into a highly approachable and culturally relevant experience.

The story could examine how established brands can use existing product strengths, rather than entirely new products, to build stronger connections with younger consumers. I would be happy to provide additional research and campaign details if useful.

Thank you for your time and consideration.

Best,

Jiayi Wu

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